

An Autistic Worker You Support / Coach

For job coaches, employment-support workers & workplace mentors — supporting an autistic adult in employment.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an adult's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." In the right role that's a superpower — depth, reliability, pattern-detection, honesty. In the wrong environment (open-plan, constant interruption, unclear expectations) it drives masking and **autistic burnout**. As a job coach or support worker you're often the bridge between a capable worker and a workplace that wasn't designed for them: help articulate adjustments, protect focus, and read the load before burnout sets in.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Exhausted, losing skills, can't recover after work	Autistic burnout — distinct from occupational burnout and depression
"Fine" at work, collapses afterwards	Heavy masking ; the cost is paid out of sight
Struggles with open-plan, meetings, hot-desking	High-channel, unpredictable environments tax a monotropic system
Won't report pain, side-effects or overload	Interoception differences; "not saying" ≠ "not suffering"
Wants everything in writing; avoids calls	Single-channel communication reduces the load

Try this

- **Help articulate reasonable adjustments** (Equality Act / ADA): quiet workspace, written instructions, fewer meetings, asynchronous communication, clear expectations.
- **Structure the role around fewer, deeper "tunnels, not tasks"** — minimise interruptions, batch shallow work, protect flow.
- **Be the predictable, safe check-in** — literal, written where helpful, focused on load and recovery.
- **Take burnout seriously** — if it's brewing, the evidence-backed move is reduce demands and allow unmasking, not "push through."
- **Centre their expertise** — they know what helps; help them ask for it.

Avoid this

- Generic "social-skills" or "push through" advice that increases masking.
- Equating a masked, competent performance with being "fine."
- Speaking *for* them without involving them in decisions.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** and **suicidality** — burnout is linked to it. Address co-occurring **ADHD (AuDHD)**, **anxiety**, **depression**, **sleep** and **GI conditions**. Where burnout is severe, validate time off, reduced hours or a role change as recovery. Signpost Access to Work / occupational health.

If the worker is a woman

Late-diagnosed women mask heavily and may look “fine” while privately exhausted; take a lifelong pattern of difference and overload seriously.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4), the **Family guide** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Raymaker et al. (2020); Knight (2021, *tunnels not tasks*); Mantzalas et al. (2022). Full citations are in the source drafts.